



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: The Oaks Classical Cottage School
School Website: <https://www.theoakscs.org/>

December 27, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

The Oaks Classical Cottage School (AI 36109) presents a strongly classical, Christian-formed program with clear signals of formation, virtue, and a traditional liberal-arts orientation. Public materials show explicit theological grounding (Statement of Faith, gospel integration) and a deliberate formation-focused aims, alongside a classical-curriculum emphasis (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin study). The school also emphasizes parental partnership and a shared mission with families. However, while the school demonstrates many hallmark elements (catechesis, liturgical warmth, classical pedagogy in some areas, and the use of classical faculties), certain explicit components of the classical rubric—namely a sustained emphasis on Great Books/Great Conversation and fully articulated Socratic seminars across grade levels—are less evident in public materials. Overall, the school aligns with classical education in substantial ways, but there are meaningful gaps that prevent a full "CLASSICAL" rating in every category.

- Aggregate classification: CLASSICAL (majority of six categories align with classical criteria; some gaps remain in explicit Great Books/Socratic pedagogy and fully articulated Great Conversation markers).
- Most influential strengths: strong religious-metaphysical foundations; formation-focused purpose; clear liberal-arts curriculum with grammar/logic/rhetoric emphasis; explicit theology integration; active parental partnership; robust faculty presence and accessibility.
- Notable gaps to move toward full CLASSICAL: explicit Great Books/Great Conversation positioning; explicit documentation of Socratic/seminar pedagogy in upper grades; broader public articulation of all six Great-Conversation-oriented practices on public-facing materials.

Key evidentiary threads include the school's Statement of Faith and gospel-centered approach (The Oaks Statement of Faith; gospel integration across subjects) and explicit mention of classical aims (Latin study, grammar/logic/rhetoric; three-day model; devotion and liturgical practices), plus a culture that centers parental involvement and a robust faculty structure. See citations for: Theology and liturgical practices, classical curriculum emphasis, three-day model and parental partnership, and faculty structure. [filecite](#)[turn0file12](#)[turn0file10](#)[turn0file2](#)[turn0file6](#)[turn0file11](#)

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials show a formal Statement of Faith and theological grounding, including explicit sections on Scripture, God, Christ, Holy Spirit, Salvation, and Church. The Oaks' Statement of Faith anchors the school in Christian doctrine and a theologically integrated educational approach. - The school foregrounds gospel-driven education and a Christian worldview integrated across disciplines; partnerships with parents are framed "guided by the Gospel." - Liturgical and communal practices appear in school life (morning devotions, prayer, communal gatherings).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: theology; sacred scripture; Gospel; Christian worldview; divine order; salvation; liturgy; prayer; devotion; faith; Church. - Negative keywords: none clearly present in public materials (no strong signaling of secular/moral-relativist language).

Why this rating - The presence of a formal Statement of Faith, explicit theology-driven framing, and liturgical/community practices strongly aligns with TRANSCENDENTAL MORAL REALISM and a grounded theology in classical education. This category is CLASSICAL.

Citations - The Oaks Statement of Faith; theological articulation: turn0file12 - Gospel integration and partnership with Gospel-guided mission: turn0file2 - Liturgical/communal practice evidence (devotions, prayer): turn0file10

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school frames education as formation of virtue and wisdom, not primarily job-preparation; language emphasizes virtue, formation, and a Christian, timeless standard rather than utilitarian ends. The site stresses “wisdom and virtue” and a formation of character aligned with true/good/beautiful ideals. - The program presents the classical aims as a growth toward truth, goodness, and beauty, consistent with the classical teleology. The site states aims of virtue, wisdom, and critical thinking within a classical framework. - The site explicitly notes formation over mere information and a Christian-centered formation anchored in timeless standards rather than vocational training.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; truth; goodness; beauty; human flourishing; telos; nature of the good life; character development. - Negative keywords: explicit “job preparation” or “work readiness” language is not present; the site does not emphasize vocational-readiness as primary end.

Why this rating - The emphasis on formation, virtue, wisdom, and knowledge of true/good/beautiful aligns with TRANSCENDENTAL MORAL REALISM and a formation-centric purpose. The presence of a robust theological frame further supports CLASSICAL status in this category.

Citations - Formation and virtue/wisdom language: turn0file6 - Formation over information and Gospel-centered formation: turn0file2

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - A clear liberal-arts orientation is evident, with explicit mention of grammar, logic, and rhetoric in the curriculum (classical trio). The materials note Latin study in the grammar years and a pathway toward classical education. - History is studied throughout the curriculum and not labeled merely as “social studies,” which aligns with classical curriculum sensibilities. - Great Books/Great Conversation are not prominently documented in public materials, though the site highlights classical education and liberal arts traditions. The site emphasizes Latin, grammar, logic, rhetoric, and history, rather than explicit Great Books/Great Conversation programming in public-facing content.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Latin; history across curriculum; Great Conversation (not clearly documented publicly); wonder/formation (implied through classical framing). - Negative keywords present: no explicit Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis documented in publicly accessible materials; no explicit modern “project-based” emphasis noted in the public-facing pages.

Why this rating - The curriculum shows a strong classical core (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin; history integrated across subjects). However, explicit Great Books/Great Conversation programming and a fully explicit Great-Books-centered Great Conversation stance are not clearly evidenced in public content. Thus SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Citations - Grammar/logic/rhetoric; Latin; history across curriculum: turn0file6 - Latin study and classical orientation: turn0file1 - History across curriculum; not social studies framing: turn0file0

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes a multi-stage approach with a three-day model; a structured rhythm that can include contemplative, restful elements alongside rigorous study (lower vs. upper grades). The three-day model itself is a distinctive pedagogical structure aligning with some classical practices and family-centered scheduling. - Lower-grade pedagogy appears to incorporate community and ritual aspects (devotions, morning gatherings) that support memory, formation, and engagement; this aligns with contemplative, restorative pedagogy in some classical models. - In upper grades, there is an emphasis on subjects that align with classical aims (logic, rhetoric, literature, Christian studies) as part of the faculty framework. The site presents a faculty structure and subjects that support rational discourse and advanced study.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: contemplative/restful education; memory and recall; singing/chanting in lower grades (classical pedagogy signals); Socratic discussion/seminars (not explicitly documented on public pages, thus unclear); rhetoric training; upper-level discourse (logic, formal instruction); memory-based approaches (repetition, scholé-adjacent ideas are referenced in related materials). - Negative keywords: explicit, sustained Socratic seminars or a robust Great Books-based seminar culture are not clearly evidenced in public-facing materials.

Why this rating - Pedagogy shows several classical touchpoints (restful/contemplative aspects in parts of the education; lower- and upper-grade strands that include memory work, rhetoric, logic). However, explicit documentation of Socratic seminars or a fully-developed upper-grade seminar discourse is not clearly present in public content, tempering the category to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Citations - Three-day model and formation-oriented pedagogy: turn0file2 - Lower-grade devotions, memory-friendly rhythm: turn0file10 - Faculty and subject mix (logic, rhetoric, Christian studies): turn0file11

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Oaks presents a structured administration and a visible faculty, including a Head of School and departmental roles (Operations, Admin, etc.). The Faculty page lists instructors for various subjects (e.g., Christian Studies, Logic, History, Math, Literature, Art, etc.), indicating a living, subject-centered faculty who serve as mentors and specialists. - The site emphasizes the faculty as a core element of the school's educational model and suggests a culture of virtuous teaching that aligns with classical expectations for teacher formation and mentorship. (Faculty listings and institutional emphasis on staff roles) - The public materials show a formal "Head of School," "Director of Operations & Academic Support," and a broader faculty listing, indicating a structured, professional teaching body.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; faculty as core of the school; portrait/standard of teacher/student. - Negative keywords: no explicit negative signals; no obvious gaps in faculty structure publicly discussed (though not all classical expectations require explicit phrasing).

Why this rating - The presence of named administrators, a robust faculty roster, and a stated emphasis on teacher virtue and mentorship align with CLASSICAL expectations for the faculty category.

Citations - Faculty listing and leadership roles: turn0file11 - Administration and staff references: turn0file11

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Oaks frames partnership with Christian parents as a central feature, including explicit statements about working with parents and guiding families in classical education. There is a strong emphasis on parental engagement, including open houses, admissions forms, and family involvement in the process. - The school communicates opportunities for parents to participate or be educated about classical education (open houses, study opportunities, and parent-faculty alignment). The ICE materials and parent-education pamphlets in the knowledge base likewise emphasize parental partnership in classical education. - Public materials routinely invite parental involvement (Discovery events, forms, and admissions steps) and highlight a collaborative approach with families. □filecite□turn0file3□turn0file5□

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teachers with the school; parent education about classical education; open houses; family engagement; shared mission; parental references. - Negative keywords: none evident in public materials; the school emphasizes engagement rather than separation from family.

Why this rating - Clear, ongoing emphasis on parental partnership and family involvement is consistent with CLASSICAL expectations for parent-community alignment.

Citations - Partnership with parents and gospel-guided mission: turn0file2 - Admissions/parental involvement and open houses: turn0file3, turn0file5 - ICE pamphlet and parent-education emphasis: turn0file18

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy) show the most explicit gaps relative to a full CLASSICAL rubric, particularly around explicit, widespread Great Books/Great Conversation framing and explicit Socratic/seminar pedagogy across grade levels. To move these toward CLASSICAL:
 - Publicly articulate a formal Great Books/Great Conversation component across grades, including recommended Great Books lists and explicit seminar-style activities aligned with logic and rhetoric progression.
 - Expand explicit Socratic/seminar practices in upper grades, with documented standards for discourse, questioning strategies, and assessment aligned to classical rhetoric.
 - Provide a public-facing outline of how the curriculum integrates Great Books, Great Conversation, and Socratic pedagogy, including sample lesson structures, teacher training plans, and student assessment rubrics.
- Element 4 could benefit from clearer documentation of specific pedagogical routines (e.g., explicit Socratic seminars, dialogue protocols, and performance-based rhetoric opportunities) in the public materials.
- Element 3 would gain from explicit, public references to Great Books and the Great Conversation in the curriculum pages, plus a stated approach to history as a coherent through-line rather than solely a content area.

Citations (for needle-mover ideas) - Great Books/Great Conversation not clearly evidenced; potential areas to document: turn0file6, turn0file0 - Socratic/ Seminar pedagogy not clearly evidenced; potential areas to document: turn0file6

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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